

China: Trade growth accelerated in May

Bottom line:

China's trade growth accelerated in May and came in above consensus expectations (exports: +19.4% yoy, imports: +27.5% yoy). The pickup in headline export growth was likely driven by stronger US-bound shipments, partly supported by a low base last year. By region, Chinese exports rose sequentially across major trading partners, except the EU and Latin America, while Chinese imports from major trading partners fell (except the US and Japan). By product, export value rose broadly from April to May, with tech-related products rising the most. Higher import value growth seems to be more price-driven than volume-led, as evidenced by the higher chip and energy prices. Overall, the trade surplus was US\$105.4bn in May, up from US\$84.8bn in April.

Asia-MAP Scores:

Exports: +3 (3, +1)

Imports: 0 (3, 0)

Key numbers:

USD-denominated:

Exports: 19.4% yoy in May (GS: 15.0%, Bloomberg consensus: 15.0%). April: 14.1% yoy. Sequential growth (seasonally adjusted by GS): 3.0% non-annualized in May vs. 4.2% in April.

Imports: 27.5% yoy in May (GS: 30.0%, Bloomberg consensus: 26.0%). April: 25.3% yoy. Sequential growth (seasonally adjusted by GS): 0.1% non-annualized in May vs. 2.2% in April.

Trade balance: US\$105.4bn NSA in May (GS: US\$86.2bn, Bloomberg consensus: US\$92.3bn). April: US\$84.8bn.

RMB-denominated:

Exports: 13.8% yoy in May vs. 9.8% yoy in April.

Imports: 21.6% yoy in May vs. 20.6% yoy in April.

Main points:

1. In year-over-year terms, China's trade growth accelerated in May. Exports increased by 19.4% yoy (vs. 14.1% yoy in April), and imports increased by 27.5% yoy (vs. 25.3% yoy in April; [Exhibit 1](#)). In sequential terms, exports grew by 3.0% sa

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non-annualized in May (vs. +4.2% in April), and imports increased by 0.1% sa non-annualized in May (vs. +2.2% in April). China's trade surplus increased to US\$105.4bn in May (not seasonally adjusted), vs. US\$84.8bn in April ([Exhibit 2](#)). Today's release of trade data only covers major trading partners and products.¹ The detailed breakdown of trade by country and by product will be [released](#) on June 20.

2. By major destination, Chinese nominal exports to major trading partners increased sequentially in May, except for the EU and Latin America ([Exhibit 3](#)). Chinese imports from major trading partners fell across major trading partners, except for the US and Japan ([Exhibit 4](#)). Among major DM countries, China's exports to the US increased by 35.4% yoy in May (vs. +11.3% yoy in April), with a sequential gain of 1.5% (mom sa non-annualized). The strong yoy increase in exports to the US partly reflects a low base [last year](#). China's imports from the US also increased by 20.4% yoy in May (vs. +9.0% yoy in April). Exports to the EU increased by 7.6% yoy in May (vs. +13.4% yoy in April), while imports from the EU fell by 1.3% yoy in May (vs. +14.5% yoy in April). Among major EM countries, exports to ASEAN increased by 24.3% yoy in May (vs. +15.2% yoy in April), with a sequential gain of 2.6%. Exports to other EMs (such as South Korea and Russia) and Africa remained strong, rising 21.9% yoy and 18.6% yoy respectively. Imports from major EM countries declined from April to May.

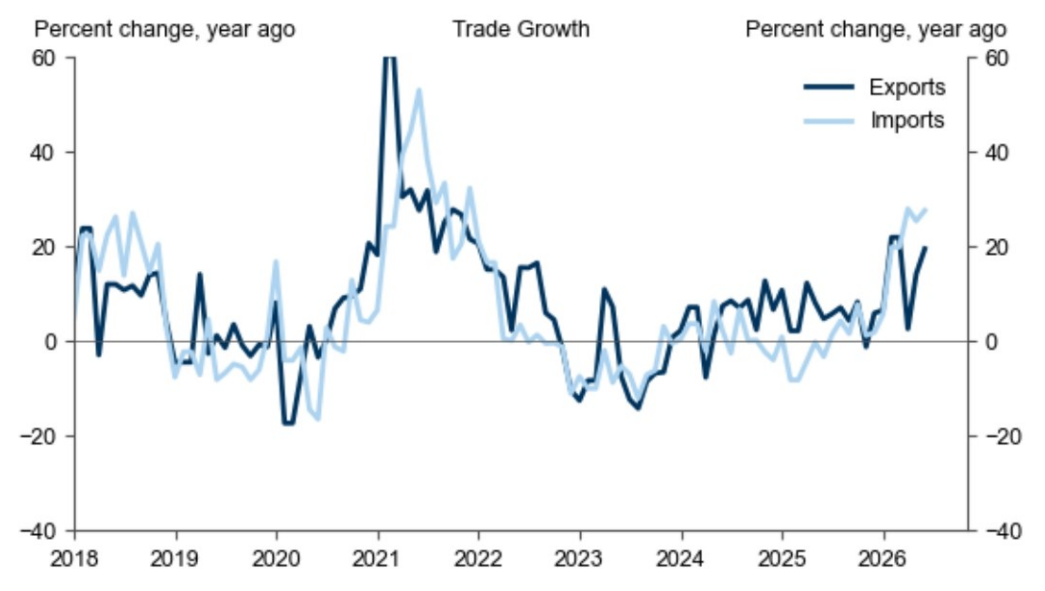
3. By major category and in sequential terms, export value rose broadly from April to May, with tech-related products rising the most, followed by metals and housing-related products. In year-over-year terms, semiconductors export value increased by 110.9% yoy in May (vs. +99.6% in April), while its export volume rose only modestly by 2.1% (vs. +3.6% in April), suggesting the increase was largely price-driven. Among metal products, exports of aluminium increased by 38.5% yoy in May (vs. +31.4% yoy in April), and exports of rare-earth ores and minerals surged by 237.4% yoy in May (vs. +196.5% yoy in April), mostly driven by price effects. Among housing-related products, exports of home appliances rose by 9.2% yoy in May (vs. +7.0% yoy in April).

4. Among major categories and in sequential terms, import value of semiconductors and automobiles increased in May, while imports of energy, metal ores, and agricultural products fell. In year-over-year terms, import value growth of semiconductors increased by 68.0% yoy in May (vs. 54.7% yoy in May), driven entirely by higher prices, as its import volume decreased by 1% yoy (vs. +11.2% in April). Higher prices continued to contribute to the increase in year-over-year import growth of energy goods. Import value of crude oil increased by 15.3% yoy in May (vs. +13.2% yoy in April), while import volume of crude oil fell by 29.0% yoy in May (vs. -20.0% yoy in April). Import value of natural gas increased by 11.0% yoy in May (vs. -14.5% yoy in April), while import volume remained roughly flat in May (vs. -12.9% yoy in April). Among major metal ores, the import value of copper ore increased by 34.0% yoy in May (vs. +16.3% yoy in April), while its import volume fell by 1.4% yoy (vs. -19.6% yoy in April). Import value of aircraft also rose sharply by 443% yoy in May (vs. -45.8% yoy in April), likely as part of the initial [purchase agreement](#) with the US following the [Trump-Xi meeting](#) in May.

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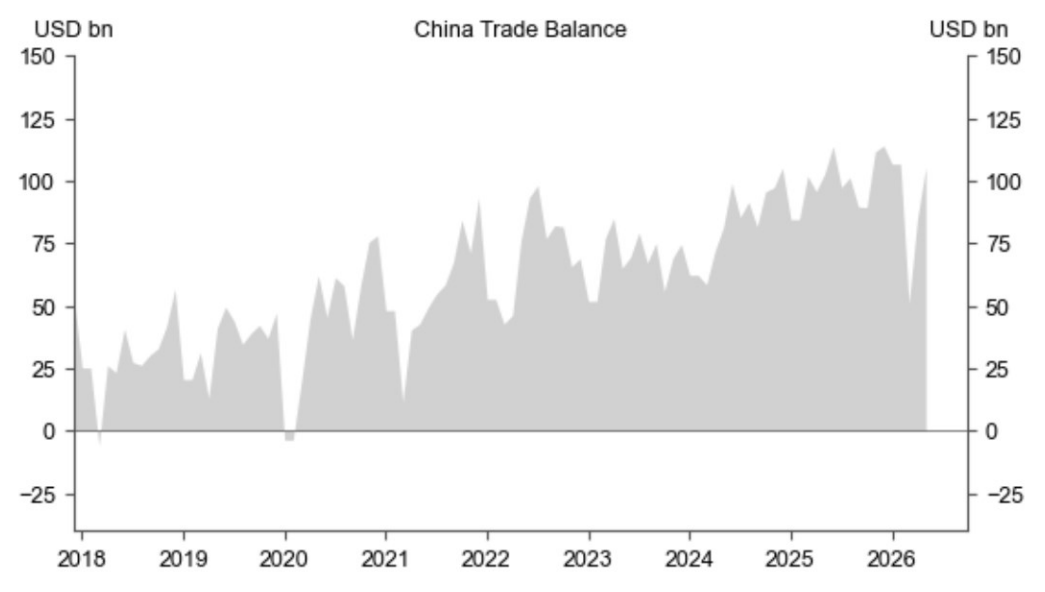
¹ Exports/imports by product cover around 40% of total exports/imports.

Exhibit 1: Year-over-year nominal trade growth accelerated in May



Source: China Customs

Exhibit 2: China’s trade surplus increased to US\$105.4bn in May



Source: China Customs

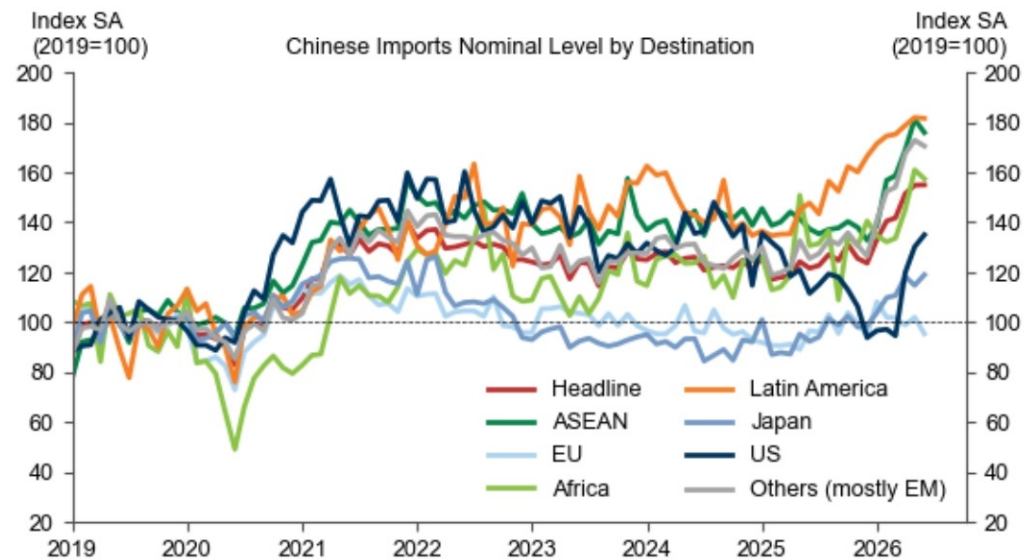
Exhibit 3: Chinese nominal exports to major trading partners increased sequentially in May, except the EU and Latin America



Chinese exports to the US/EU/Japan/ASEAN/LatAm/Africa were around 13.2%/14.6%/4.2%/17.1%/7.8%/5.4% of total exports in 2025. Overall they accounted for 62% of Chinese exports.

Source: China Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: Chinese imports from major trading partners fell sequentially in May, except the US and Japan



Chinese imports from the US/EU/Japan/ASEAN/LatAm/Africa were around 6.1%/10.3%/6.2%/15.5%/9.3%/4.6% of total imports in 2025. Overall they accounted for 52% of Chinese imports.

Source: China Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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